simple concept of identifying the decisive mistake and the key person who made that mistake.

Humility in public

We must necessarily peer into the unknown when we choose between multiple solutions to a visible problem. In most cases, it is not entirely clear what solution is superior. To avoid paralysis, we have to be willing to make mistakes.

This requires creating an environment that is more supportive of failure. We need to put aside the machismo, be honest in saying what we know and what we don't know, and approach every policy initiative as a process of hypothesis testing.

If a policymaker lays claim to omniscience and benevolence, this can lead to two outcomes. On one hand, the policymaker can be afflicted by hubris, and suffer from unintended consequences and failure. On the other hand, the policymaker may achieve a genuine understanding of the complexities that are faced, and retreat into paralysis owing to fear of failure that is incompatible with the public claims about omniscience.

A key part of this is the allocation of credit. In authoritarian regimes, all achievements belong to the leader, which makes it difficult to ever admit that a mistake was made. When credit is given more accurately, to the cast of thousands that work on any one policy initiative, it is easier for the leadership to accept that things have not worked out well and to introduce course corrections. The best management culture is one in which we *get credit for not taking credit*. This helps create a healthy environment of trying things, accepting that some did not work, and abandoning or fixing the troubled ones.

The mass media sensationalizes success or failure. It puts frail humans on a pedestal, and attributes godlike powers upon them. There is a need for greater maturity on both sides, in the media and in the policy community. Policymakers need to speak clearly about imperfect knowledge, and others